

Disk shopping



- ✓ Speed or space? If you need to store MP3s and DivX films, or back up heavy image files, buy the largest hard disk you can afford. On the other hand, if you use applications such as image editing, or audio processing software extensively, look for the fastest hard disk you can afford—at least a 7,200-rpm drive.
- ✓ Do a bit of market research. Ask your friends, dealers, or search the Internet for information about the manufacturer, their reputation, and their after sales service.
- ✓ Check the warranty type covered, apart from the time frame offered. Some manufacturers provide a hard disk replacement only in the first year, after which they only offer to repair it. This is rather unreliable, and can lead to further problems.
- ✓ Confirm the time it takes to replace a faulty hard disk. This is important, especially, if your business relies heavily on data storage. Generally, manufacturers running service centres are able to provide quick replacements. Those who don't could take weeks to replace a faulty hard disk.
- ✓ Check for accessories such as IDE cables, disk management software, and operating manuals.

type of power supply connector, so that you don't get stuck if you don't have the SATA power connector cable. Feature wise, the 160 GB drives from both, Seagate, and Maxtor, were at par, employing the same amount of buffer, and spindle speed, the only exception being the power connector—Seagate only provided a SATA connector.

Performance analysis

Before we delve deep into the performance of these hard drives, we would like to clarify certain points. The first point is the difference in the two interfacing standards—the older IDE interface, also called PATA (Parallel ATA), and the newer SATA (Serial ATA). Though SATA is a new standard that was supposed to offer better performance than an IDE drive, this does not quite hold true. However, the limitations seem to be in the first generation of SATA drives. As newer versions of the same technology are released, the performance will increase. As of now, SATA only offers advantages

such as smaller, and thinner cables that lessen the cluster of cables inside the PC cabinet, thus improving its thermal dynamics. Also, the cables are simpler to install, and moreover, since there is no jumper selection, or a master slave concept, installation is a cakewalk. One more thing that we would like to point out is that the older 5,400 rpm drives are now slowly vanishing. Hence, opt for a 7,200 rpm drive, since they offer a better performance, and are priced sensibly.



Maxtor DiamondMax PlusII 6Y20M0

HD-TACH

HD-Tach is an excellent benchmark to figure out the performance of a drive. This benchmark offers the average read write speed, along with the burst speed, and the CPU utilisation of the drive. The burst speed is the speed at which data can be accessed from the drive's on-board read-ahead memory. The higher the score, the better the performance of the drive. At the same time, it is also

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